Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 6 5 4 2 ♥ A K 8 7 4 ♦ A ♣ K 3	
♠ A 9 8 ♥ Q 5 2 ♦ 9 7 5 4 ♣ Q 10 6	N W E S	♠ Q J 10 7 3 ♥ J 3 ♦ 8 6 2 ♣ J 9 5
	♠ — ♥ 10 9 6 ♦ K Q J 10 3 ♣ A 8 7 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by North
Lead: ♠Q

South's 6♥ response to Blackwood showed one Ace and a ♠ void. North is to play 6♥. East leads the ♠Q.

West plays the ♠8 and you the ♠2.

Losers: ♠ = ?? ♥ = 1 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 1 ??

Of course you ruff the ♠ in dummy. East wouldn't underlead an Ace at a slam contract, and since you have a certain trump loser you cannot afford to lose a trick to West's ♠A.

Dummy has some great ♦s, but you can't expect to run them unless you have pulled all the trumps. But if you play ♥ A K 4 the defenders will take their trump trick and immediately set the contract with the ♠A. There **IS** a way around the problem.

West plays low.

East wins with the ♥J.

First off, you must get a 3-2 split in trumps because if they don't split 3-2 you will have two trump losers. So you assume that they are split just like you need them to be.

At trick two you duck a trump. That's right, you lose a trump trick early. Since you have to lose a trump sometime, you do it at a time when the defenders can't hurt you. So a defender wins the trump trick, but now a ♠ play won't hurt because dummy still has a trump to ruff with! In fact, whatever they play next you will win, pull the outstanding trumps, then run dummy's ♦ suit.

This is a very rare play, but a good one to remember.

When you have a trump loser but still need to pull their trumps, it may be better for you to lose an early trump trick rather than a later one.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 6 5
♥ 5 4 3 2
♦ Q 2
♣ K Q 9 7 3

♠ A K Q
♥ A K 9 8
♦ A 10 8 6 3
♣ 5

♠ 7 4 2
♥ Q J 10 7
♦ 5
♣ A 8 6 4 2

♠ J 10 9 8 3
♥ 6
♦ K J 9 7 4
♣ J 10

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	1♥	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠J

Agreed that the bidding wasn't much. The final contract is still a good one. East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠J.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 4

There really aren't 4 ♣ losers since they can be ruffed in dummy. In fact you should see that this is an ideal cross-ruff hand, ruffing ♣s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. Since neither hand can be over-ruffed you expect to make all 8 trumps.

Remember, when playing a cross ruff, you need to take any side suit winners first, otherwise a defender may be able to discard that suit while you are ruffing. So you win the ♠A, then take the ♠K, then . . . what?

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Well, if you win the ♠Q, then the two Minor suit Aces, you'd be set up to cross-ruff the hand out for all 13 tricks. But here's what might happen if you try.

North might ruff the ♠Q. OK, no disaster yet. But he might then play a trump. Your slam is now kaput. You can no longer make 8 trump tricks and will end up down 1.

The answer is to not be greedy for that overtrick. With South's opening ♠ lead there is an indication of possible length there. So, realizing that North could be short in the suit, take just the 2 ♠ tricks that you need for the slam, then play your Minor Aces and start the cross-ruff.

When playing a cross-ruff you must take all the side-suit winners you need early so they won't get ruffed later.

Don't jeopardize your contract trying to take too many.